Introduction

We are living in a green planet. Plenty of natural plant resources are around us. Economic botany basically deals with all pervading plants in relation to human welfare as food, clothing, shelter and medicine either directly or indirectly.

Indirect usage includes the needs of mans' livestock and the maintenance of the environment; the benefits may be domestic, commercial, environmental, or aesthetic.

Plants bring about economy to the country in large extent and it is a fact that the wealth of any country largely depends upon its agriculture and plant products.

Economic botany is the study of relationship between people and plants and the uses of plants in economy.

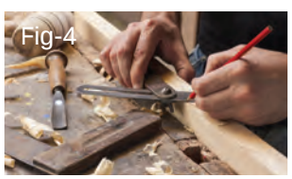
From the earliest time rice, wheat and millet have been the staple food of a vast population of India as indicated by the presence of charred grains in most of the excavation sites. In addition, references are abundant in ancient literature about the existence and usage of several crops of economic importance.

Observe the following pictures carefully. Can you identify what they are doing?


Fig-1


Fig-2


Fig-3


Fig-4

1. Why are the farmers harvesting paddy?
2. A woman makes rope using coir. Where does the raw material come from?
3. Neem leaves are being collected in a plate. Do you know the uses of neem leaves?
4. What material is used by the man to make a chair?

In this lesson, let us discuss about the different crop plants of economic uses in relation to mankind. Based on their economic values and uses, plants may be broadly classified as follows.

1. **Plants as Food**
2. **Spice yielding plants**
3. **Medicinal plants**
4. **Fibre yielding plants**
5. **Timber yielding plants**
6. **Ornamental plants**

5.1 Plants as Food

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Plants are the main source of food for humans beings. These plants are known as **food plants.**

Do you have a vegetable garden in your house? Have you ever seen harvesting of ripened vegetables?

Which part of the plants is used as food for us?

We eat different parts of plants such as root, stem, leaf, seed unripe and ripe fruits. We can classify the food plants as follows.

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